

"Sleep is not a passive process. Your body may seem immobile but a lot is going on inside. We also have to go through all sleep stages to wake up rested"

DR PADMA SUNDARAM, ***Sleep specialist, Fortis, Cunningham Rd, Bengaluru***

How can we fix sleep debt?

Sleep being a complex psycho-physiological phenomenon, no one solution can treat the lack of it. The approach has to be holistic, on the basis of an individual's biological, psychological and social factors. The good news is that sleep medicine has come a long way in India. "Sleep medicine was virtually non-existent when I started my career about four decades ago," says Dr Suri. "Today, sleep apnea can be treated with CPAP (continuous positive airway pressure) machines, dental devices and surgery. Many new medicines have also been developed." Most urban multi-speciality hospitals in the country now have sleep labs and sleep specialists.

And the first thing a sleep specialist does is take down your history to determine the precise cause of your sleep debt. "History is the most important for diagnosis of sleep," says Dr Prakash. "To know how someone lives their life—do they snore, what is their job, their lifestyle, sleep routine and so on. Sometimes, a patient can go for overnight polysomnography at their residence or the sleep lab at a hospital to diagnose if there is a medical issue disturbing sleep." Treatment is recommended accordingly. This can range from psychiatric help to improved sleep hygiene. "Certain novel treatments like targeting inhibition of wakeful centres in the brain are also available apart from traditional sleeping tablets that work on sleep centres. Hormonal treatment and light therapy are useful for circadian rhythm issues," explains Dr Ramaiah.

The trouble is, despite these advances in sleep medicine, very few people actually consult the relevant specialist to treat their sleep disorders. As far back as 2015, a study of 1,185 participants in West Bengal published in the *International Journal of Medicine and Public Health* found that nearly half of those who had insomnia had never sought medical advice and only 15.3 per cent actually consulted a doctor for sleep issues.

Sleep apnea is another common issue that often goes unaddressed. Snoring is its first symptom, but very few who suffer from it realise its impact on their wellbeing. "One must consult a sleep specialist if one snores loudly, has difficulty remaining asleep, or gets up frequently to urinate," says Dr Suri. "One should also consider sleep consultation for excessive sleepiness during the daytime or uncontrolled hypertension despite medication." In 2019, the *National Medical Journal of India*, after highlighting the adverse effects of poor sleep, even recommended a National Sleep Policy to spread awareness, promote good sleep hygiene and improve accessibility to sleep medicine.

Many also choose to diagnose their own sleep problems with sleep apps, and self-treat them too, via breathable clothes, weighted blankets, sleep-based vacations, melatonin gummies and yoga. According to data collecting portal Statista, the global sleep economy is set to grow to $585 billion in 2024 from $432 billion in 2019. In India, Future Market Insights predicts just the melatonin supplement market to cross $10 million by 2033, and the sleep aids market is likely to hit $455 million by 2029, according to Statista. Mattress companies are adapting their offerings to target customers who are interested in improving their sleep. So, Wakefit offers a 100-day return policy because they know it takes time for a customer to adjust to a new sleep mattress and decide if it suits their body. "Lumpy mattresses significantly impact sleep quality by causing discomfort, disrupting sleep patterns, and creating pressure points that lead to pain and stiffness. This can result in restless nights, frequent tossing and turning, and discomfort in the back and neck due to poor spinal alignment," says Ankit Garg, CEO and Co-founder, Wakefit.co.

Natural or alternate cures are the other ways people are fixing their sleep. Homegrown brand Cosmix acquired a customer base of 15,000 within a few months of the release of their sleep supplement, Sleep Like a Baby. The mix contains adaptogens (natural substances that restore equilibrium in the body) such as Scisandra berry and Ashwagandha. Neeti Chadha 38, a Delhi-based banking executive, puts her faith in the many herbal teas linked to better sleep quality. "Even if it is a placebo effect, it is still helping me sleep better, and there are no side-effects," she says. Dr Suri is more sceptical. "There is no harm in taking herbal teas or supplements within limits," he says, "but if it isn't improving your sleep, you must go see a doctor. A supplement is meant to be taken alongside a proper line of medical treatment, it is not the treatment by itself. I also strongly advise against self-medicating with melatonin because it can disrupt your body's natural rhythm."

So, take that snoozecation at a luxury hotel and use a guided breathing app to relax before bedtime, but also see that sleep doctor. Only that will permanently end your sleep debt. ■